Udhampur, bordered by a ridgeline of green hills. Here we got a chance to speak to some of the officers of the station. But compared to the male cadets from the academy, they were almost reluctant to converse with us and were mostly cold in their behaviour, much like my unit's adjutant. We had a quiet dinner and went to our room to prepare our uniforms for the next day. The next morning after the mass briefing, we reached our unit by walking quite a distance. There was no difference in the behaviour of the unit officers there either; it was as if our presence was making them uncomfortable, and everyone was eerily quiet. Wing Commander Parab, the flight commander of the unit, took us to the commanding officer, Group Captain D'Silva, for our interview. The commanding officer was the only person we felt was warm to us and made us feel comfortable, while at the same time reiterated that our endeavour should be to learn and bring laurels to the unit by performing well, something that is expected of all young officers of any unit.

To prove our merit in our first unit, we were told to appear for a gen test to verify a pilot's knowledge about the aircraft, functioning and controls, safety procedures, etc. The test was akin to the one we had appeared for during the training. The CO even offered his old scooter to us, since commuting from the officers' mess to the unit location in the station was quite troublesome due to the long distances involved. We took the scooter from him in the evening and sat down in our room to prepare for the gen test, which was due the next morning. We performed poorly and even though we were scolded for our performance in the gen test, which we duly deserved, we were allowed to start flying. Consequently, an acceptance check sortie was scheduled on the third day, which was the first time I went airborne in that area and familiarized myself with the terrain, maps and other instructions. It was also the first time I flew in the hills.

Later that day, an officer told us that the reason the other officers were refraining from talking to us was because we were the first women pilot officers to be posted to that station, and prior to our reaching the station, all male officers were briefed to behave themselves while we were around and not get too friendly with us. Such behaviour was obvious and adjusting